PREFACE:
A HEALTH WARNING TO THE READER

This book is mostly about South India and aspects of its cultural history that I find particularly fascinating – or challenging. I do not claim for one moment that it is more 'correct' as history than anything else that has been written, only that it is my attempt to make sense of some of the forces and contradictions that have shaped the multifarious culture of the Indian South – hence my subtitle 'a personal history'. Although written for a general readership I very much hope it will also appeal to English-speaking readers in India and to HINAs (Hindus in North America) and HIBs (Hindus in Britain) – hence my health warning.

I write as a secular humanist. Despite my Indian roots, my cultural attitudes have been shaped largely by Britain, which is an increasingly secular society. We British are in general not just irreligious but downright anti-religious. A recent survey carried out by the *Observer* newspaper showed that 61 per cent of the British population thought that religion is 'a negative influence in the world rather than a force for good'. Only 15 per cent disagreed.[1]

On the Indian subcontinent it is very much the other way round. Religion continues to shape South Asian society to a degree unthinkable in most of Europe – although not in the United States of America, where polls suggest that around 42 per cent of Americans believe in Creationism and only 19 per cent in Darwinian evolution.

So reader, if you truly believe that Hanuman and his monkey army helped Rama build a bridge linking the Indian